The British Investor's Guide: London to Dubai

UK tax comparison · Three emirates · Golden Visa · Financing · Updated July 2026

AED 419.9B	0%	6.58%
DUBAI H1 2026 TRANSACTIONS	INCOME & CAPITAL GAINS TAX	DUBAI AVG GROSS YIELD

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Dubai recorded AED 419.9 billion in H1 2026 transactions — the second-best half-year on record. For British investors the arithmetic is structural: zero income tax, zero capital gains tax, zero annual property tax, and gross yields of 6.5–9% across three emirates — versus London gross yields of 4.0–5.2% (zone-dependent) eroded by up to 45% income tax, 28% CGT, and 3–17% stamp duty.

UK VS UAE: THE TAX COMPARISON

Tax type	United Kingdom	UAE	Advantage
Income tax on rentals	20–45%	0%	Keep 100% of rent
Capital gains tax	18–28%	0%	No tax on sale profits
Stamp duty (purchase)	3–17% SDLT	4% DLD fee	Lower entry cost
Inheritance tax	40% above £325K	0%	Full wealth transfer
Annual property tax	Council tax £1–4K	0%	No holding cost
Net rental yield	~2.5–4%	5–6.5%	~2x net income

THREE EMIRATES: WHERE BRITISH CAPITAL FINDS RETURNS

Emirate	Entry/sqft	Gross yield	Catalyst	Best for
Dubai	AED 1,300–4,200+	6.5–8%	Al Maktoum Airport, Dubai 2040	Liquidity & depth
Abu Dhabi	AED 900–2,500	5–7%	Saadiyat Cultural District	Stability & yield
Ras Al Khaimah	AED 1,000–1,600	7–9%	Wynn Al Marjan, Spring 2027	Highest yield

RESIDENCY & FINANCING

10-year Golden Visa requires property worth AED 2M+ (since Feb 2026, off-plan qualifies on the registered Oqood price — no minimum paid equity; mortgaged properties qualify with a bank NOC). Properties from AED 750K qualify for a 2-year renewable residence visa (Taskeen).

Non-resident financing: banks typically lend 50–60% LTV to non-residents (40–50% cash down), rates roughly 4–6%, off-plan capped near 50%. UK equity release at 5–6% funding UAE assets yielding 6.5–9% gross creates positive carry — with zero tax on the differential.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Sterling buys 4.9+ AED, yields are roughly double London's net, and H1 2026's ready-market strength means you can buy completed, income-producing assets from day one. The window is structural, not cyclical.

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